



The Coupon Community

I loved writing term papers and research papers in high school. I was one of the few students who actually preferred essay tests. I learned the rudimentary skills of conducting research at the hands of a high school teacher who took us to a college library to show us how to seek out answers to our questions. Later, beginning classes at that same college, I already knew where the green *Reader's Guide to Periodicals* were located and became a pro at reading news articles on microfilm and microfiche (I know, I'm really dating myself). As an undergraduate, I was required to take a class in statistics where we typed our facts and figures into a machine that transformed them into a stack of cards with holes punched into them. These punch cards were then fed into a computer that filled an entire room.

Fast forward to the summer of 2006: My husband was just diagnosed with oral cancer, and I found myself, once again, doing research. This time, in front of a desktop computer. I was amazed at the ease and speed that I was able to obtain information.

So it has been in researching the science of shopping and the history of coupon use. Everything I wanted to know was just a mouse click away. Not just that, but I already had a built-in community of avid couponers and former refunders to interview. They were the consumers in the trenches of